A FIELD GUIDE BY ALEXANDRA STUDIO

Velvet Rope



EXPERIENTIAL MARKETING & IDENTITY MOTIVATION

How exclusive, in-person brand experiences build trust, and how B2B companies can create their own

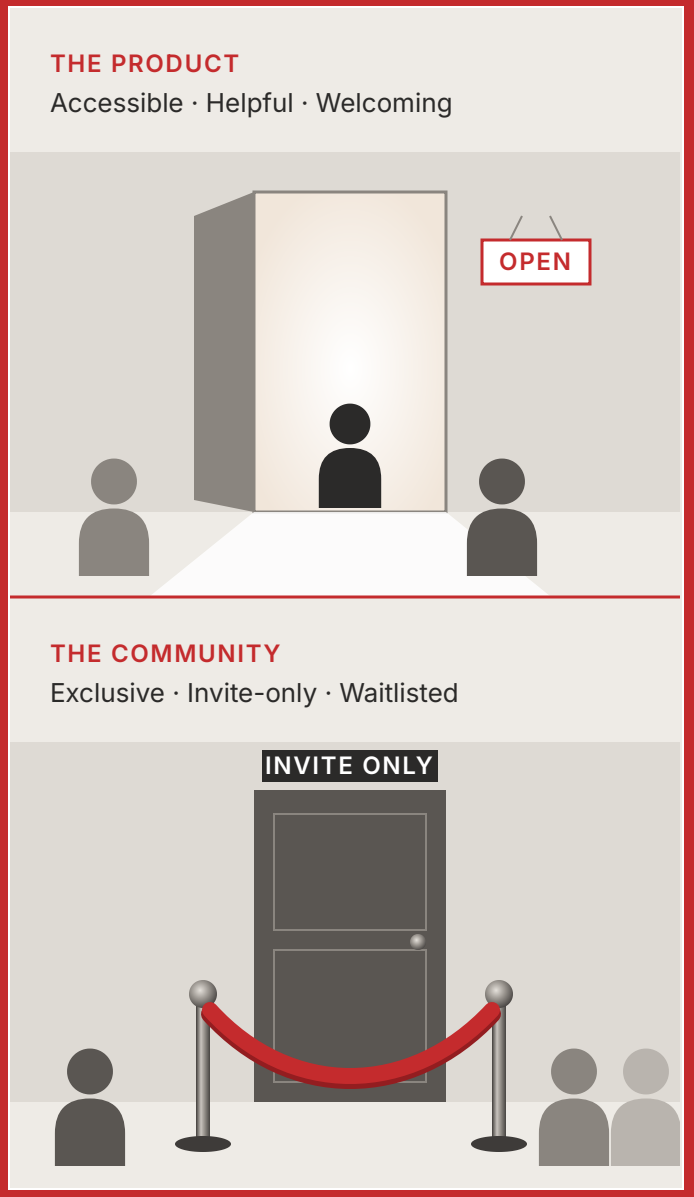


CLAUDE THE PRODUCT IS OPEN TO EVERYONE.
CLAUDE THE COMMUNITY HAS A WAITLIST.

How does this exclusive, in-person brand experience actually work?

Can other companies replicate it to engage new potential customers and spark their curiosity?

An odd *club*



THE POST THAT WENT VIRAL ON LINKEDIN

“Getting into a Claude meet-up in Copenhagen is harder than getting into *McKinsey.*”

MICHAEL HAASE
GTM Community Builder at Lovable, Copenhagen
Ex-McKinsey

One line. Instant curiosity, and instant FOMO.

THE QUESTIONS IT PLANTS

01 · CONFUSION
Why is it hard to get into Claude meet-ups?

02 · THE OUT-GROUP
Why can't *I* get into the Claude meet-up?

03 · THE DEMAND
How do I get into the Claude meet-up?

THE CUSTOMER'S SEQUENCE OF THOUGHT

Outside, looking *in*



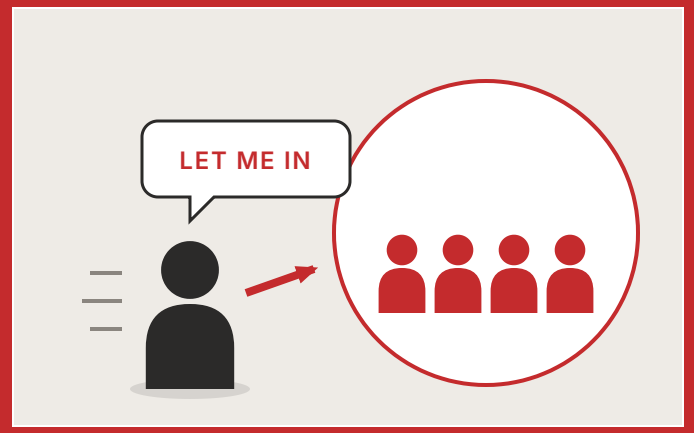
01 *Confusion*

"Why is it so hard to get in?"



02 *The out-group*

Realizing they are on the outside.



03 *The demand*

Insisting they belong in the in-group.

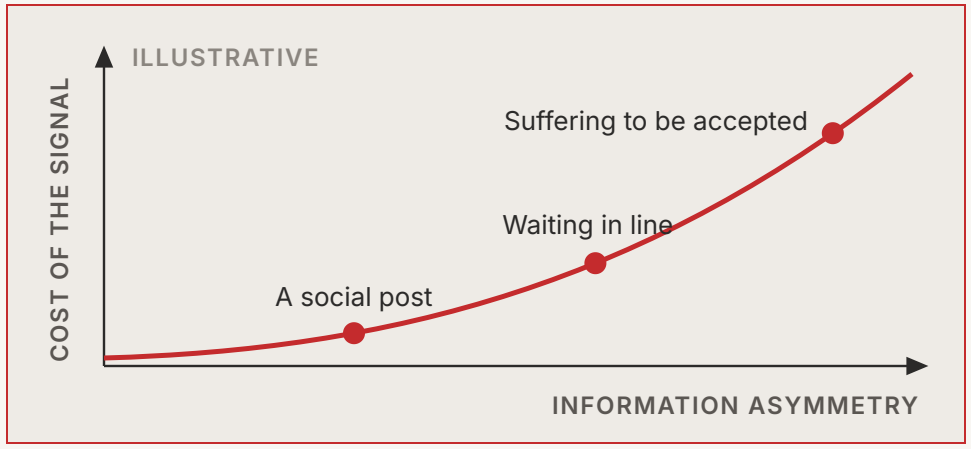
INFORMATION ASYMMETRY CREATES A DYNAMIC OF POWER

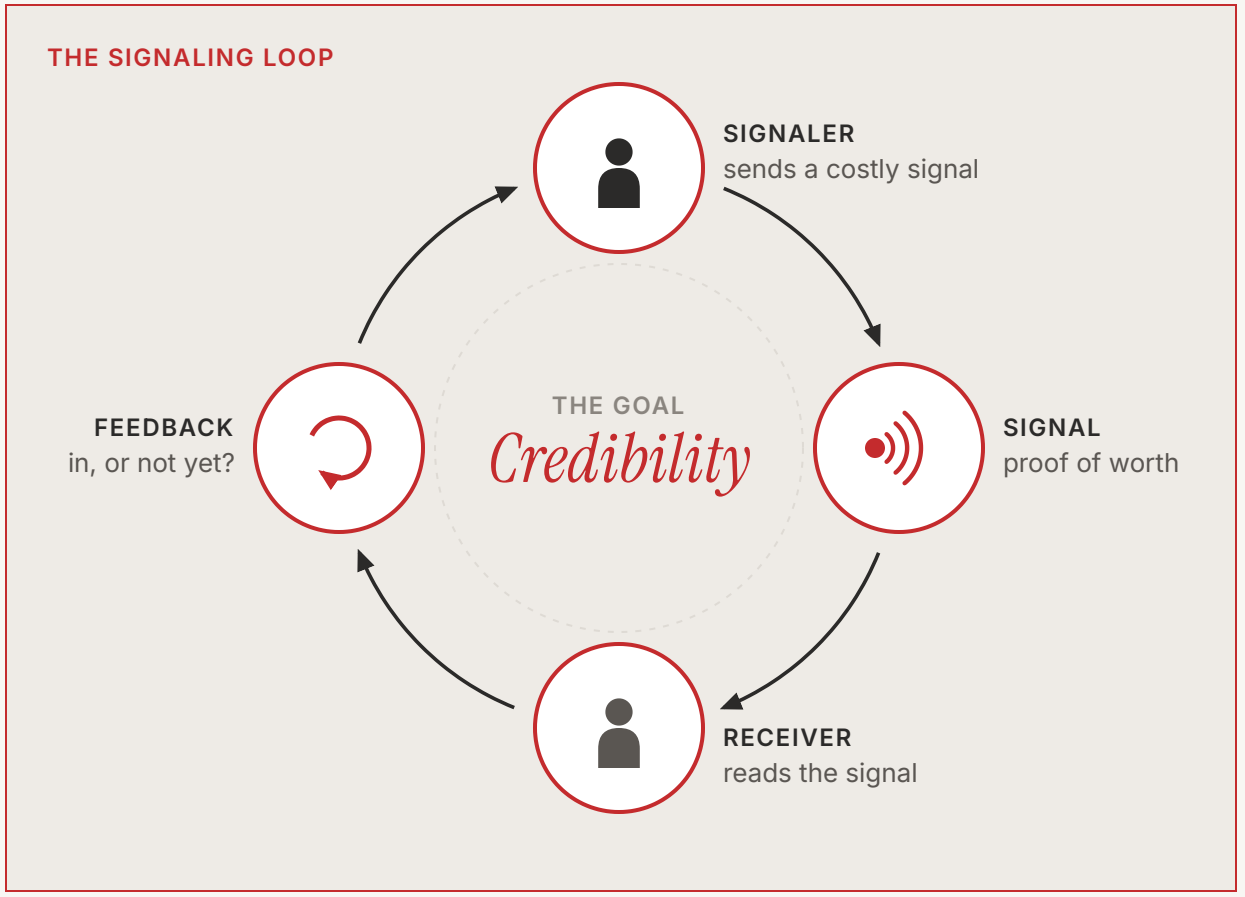
⚠ ...BUT RESEARCH SUGGESTS THE BOUNDARY CAN DECREASE TRUST

Signaling *theory*

A HUMAN RESPONSE TO INFORMATION ASYMMETRY.

There is the **signaler**, the **signal**, the **receiver** and the **feedback**. As asymmetry increases, the signaler sends more expensive, costly signals to gain credibility with the receiver, hoping to join the in-group.





HOW THE BOUNDARY IS DRAWN

Holding a *secret*

INVITE-ONLY

LIMITED SPEAKER DROPS

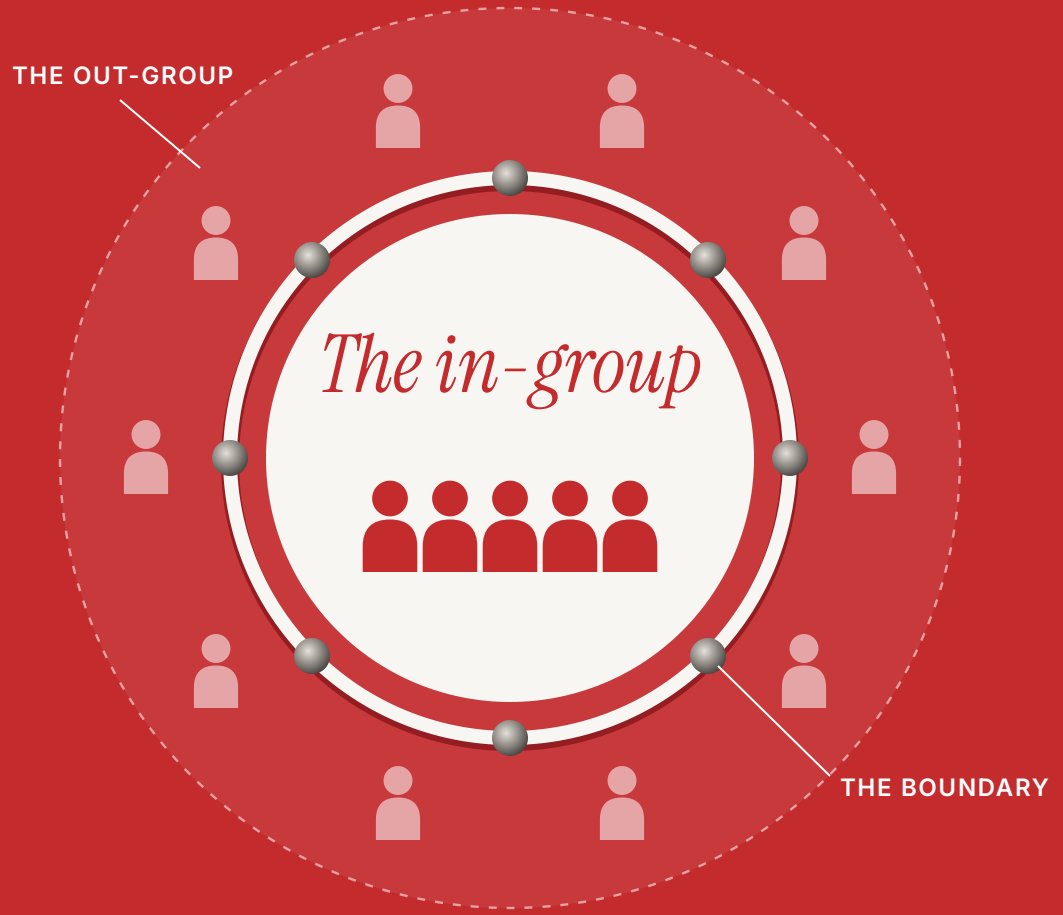
BOUNDARIES ARE DRAWN

INFORMATION ASYMMETRY

AN IN-GROUP & AN OUT-GROUP

CONTROLLED VISIBILITY

The VIP feeling

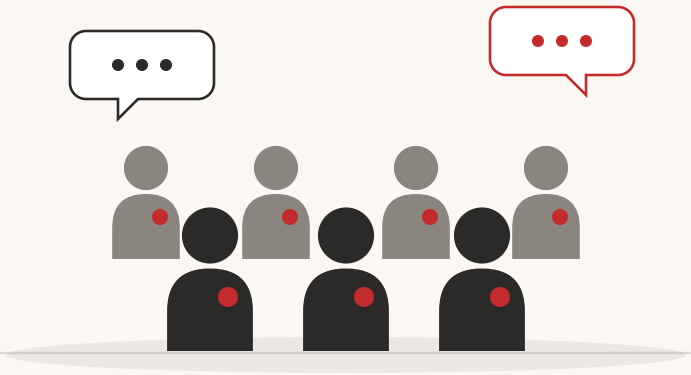


VISIBILITY ON BOTH SIDES OF THE ROPE

Seen from *both sides*

INSIDERS

must be recognizable to one another

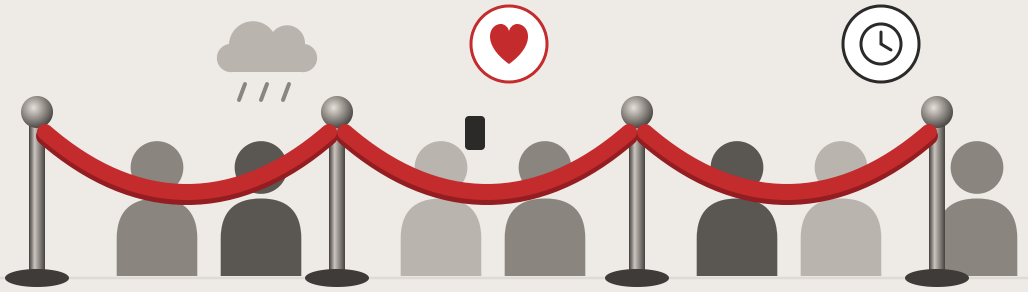


TASTE | DRESS CODE | LANGUAGE | LOCATION | SOCIAL STATUS

Shared markers that signal who belongs.

OUTSIDERS

must be visible, too



LONG LINES | SUFFERING TO BE ACCEPTED

SOCIAL POSTS DESCRIBING THEIR EXCITEMENT

HOW THE DEMAND BECOMES REAL

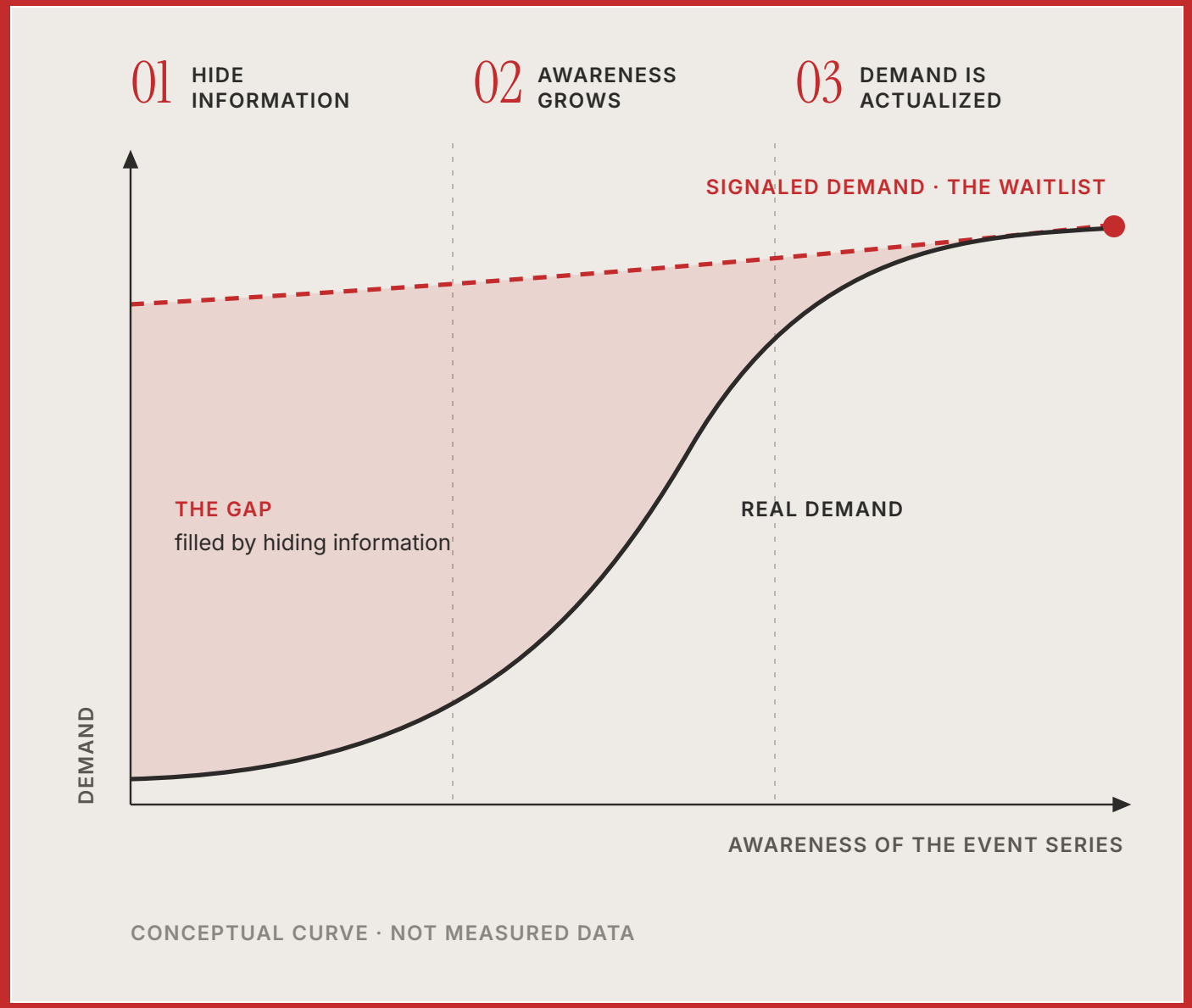
Artificial, then *actual*

This is almost always created artificially at first, strategically, by hiding information. Then, as awareness of the event series increases, the demand becomes actualized.

01 Hide information to draw the boundary

02 Awareness of the event series grows

03 Real demand catches up with the waitlist

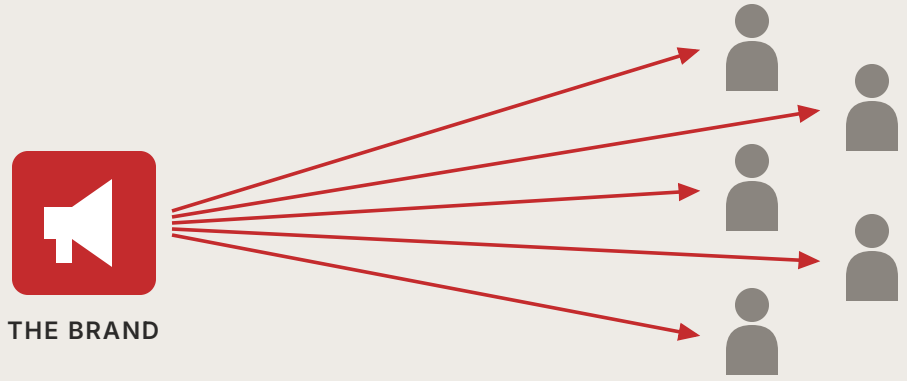


TWO KINDS OF MARKETING

Monologue vs *dialogue*

TRADITIONAL MARKETING

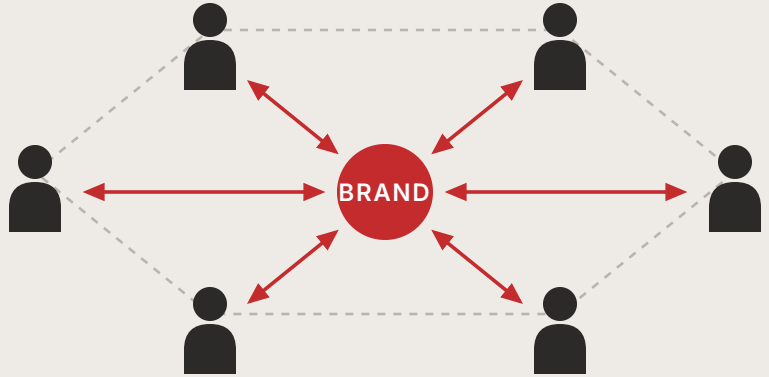
A monologue



Messages pushed toward the customer

EXPERIENTIAL MARKETING

A dialogue



Goal: increase awareness, trust and credibility

Customers expect helpfulness: relevant information, interpreted and conveyed

Voluntary participation, not messages forced on people

Interactive: a dialogue rather than a monologue

WHERE EXPERIENTIAL MARKETING COMES FROM

A short *history*

"Lived experiences in hyperreality"

The theoretical term for what these brand experiences create.



1980s

GERMANY

Experiential marketing (Erlebnismarketing) emerges: voluntary, interactive participation instead of a one-way brand monologue.



For decades

CONSUMER FASHION BRANDS

Adidas, Patagonia and Nike build lived experiences around their communities.



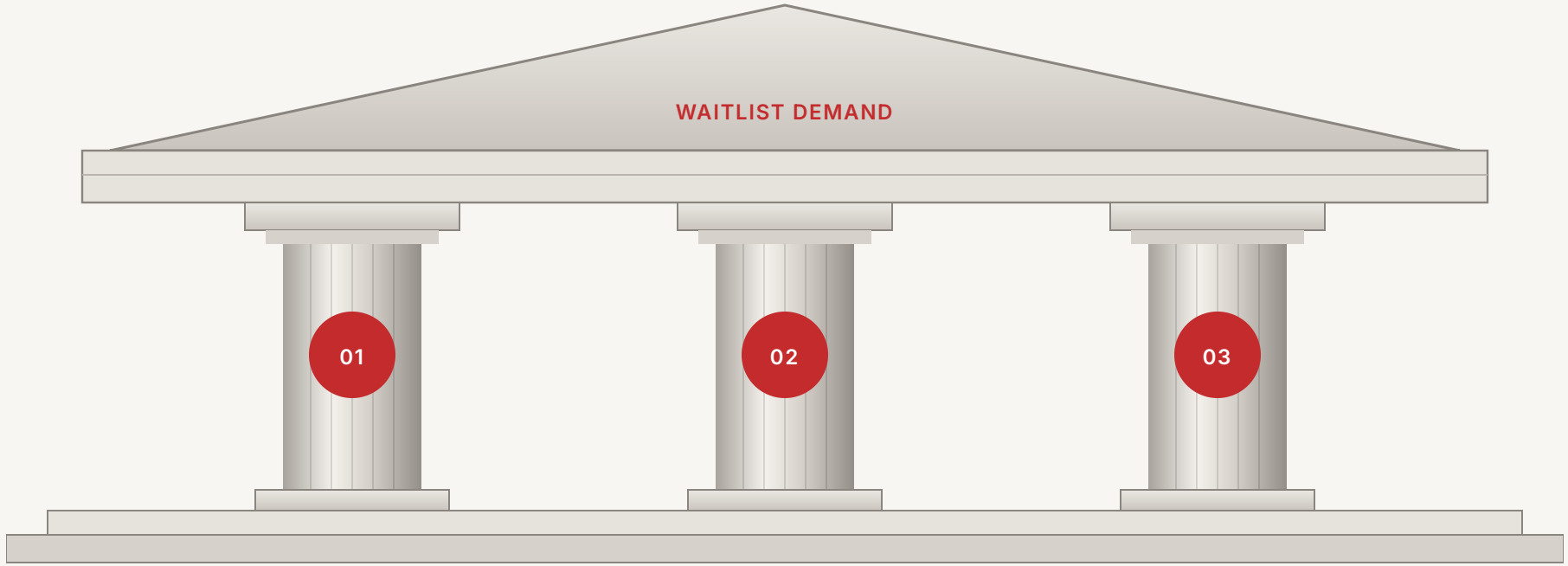
Now

BUSINESS-TO-BUSINESS

What about B2B brands? The Claude Community phenomenon is experiential marketing based on identity motivation theory.

Three *questions*

TO BUILD TRUST THROUGH VOLUNTARY PARTICIPATION, AND EARN WAITLIST DEMAND, ANSWER THREE QUESTIONS.



TRUST

How do we define trust?

MOTIVATION

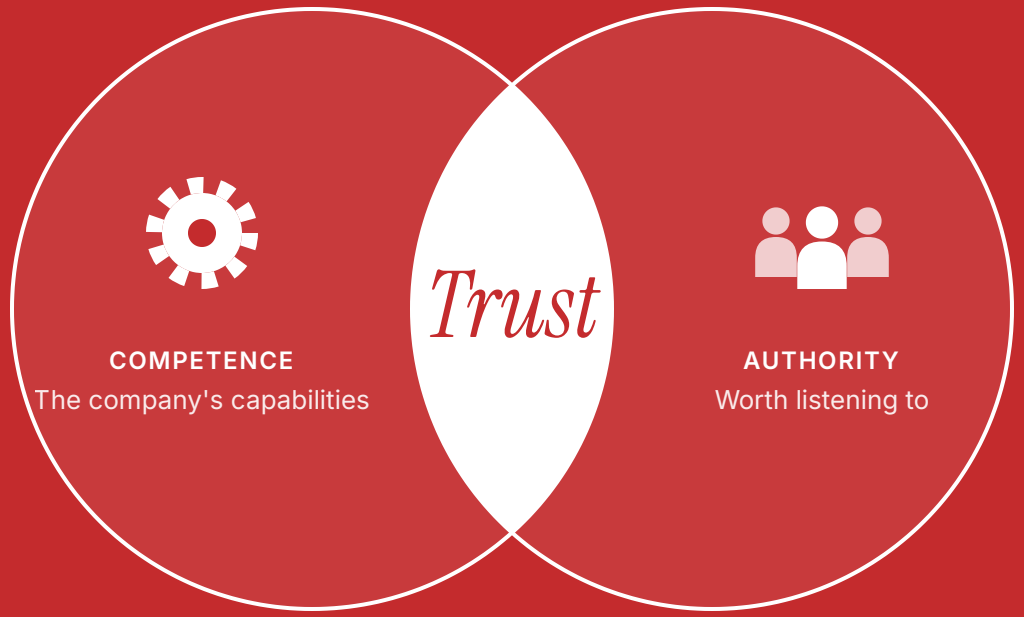
What motivates people to join in-person events?

MEASUREMENT

How do we know it's a worthy investment?

Defining *trust*

TRUST WORKS BY CONVEYING COMPETENCE: CAPABILITY AND AUTHORITY.



Customers can agree that your company has the capabilities it says it has.

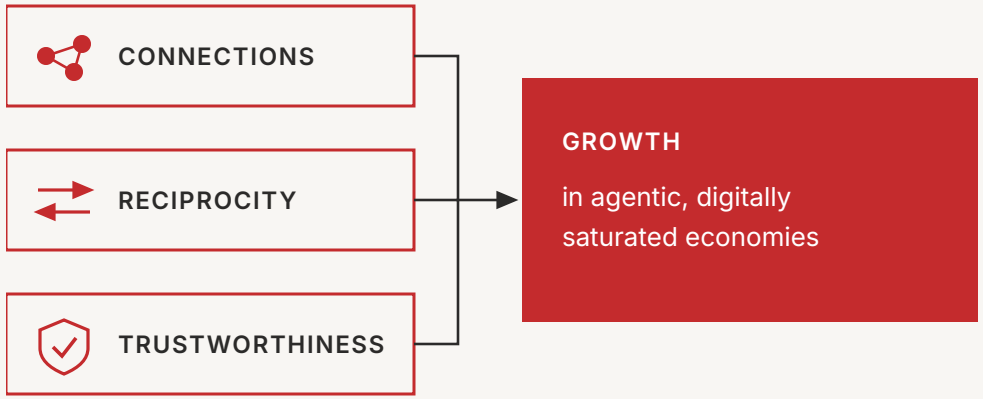
Other people joining in means your company has authority worth listening to.

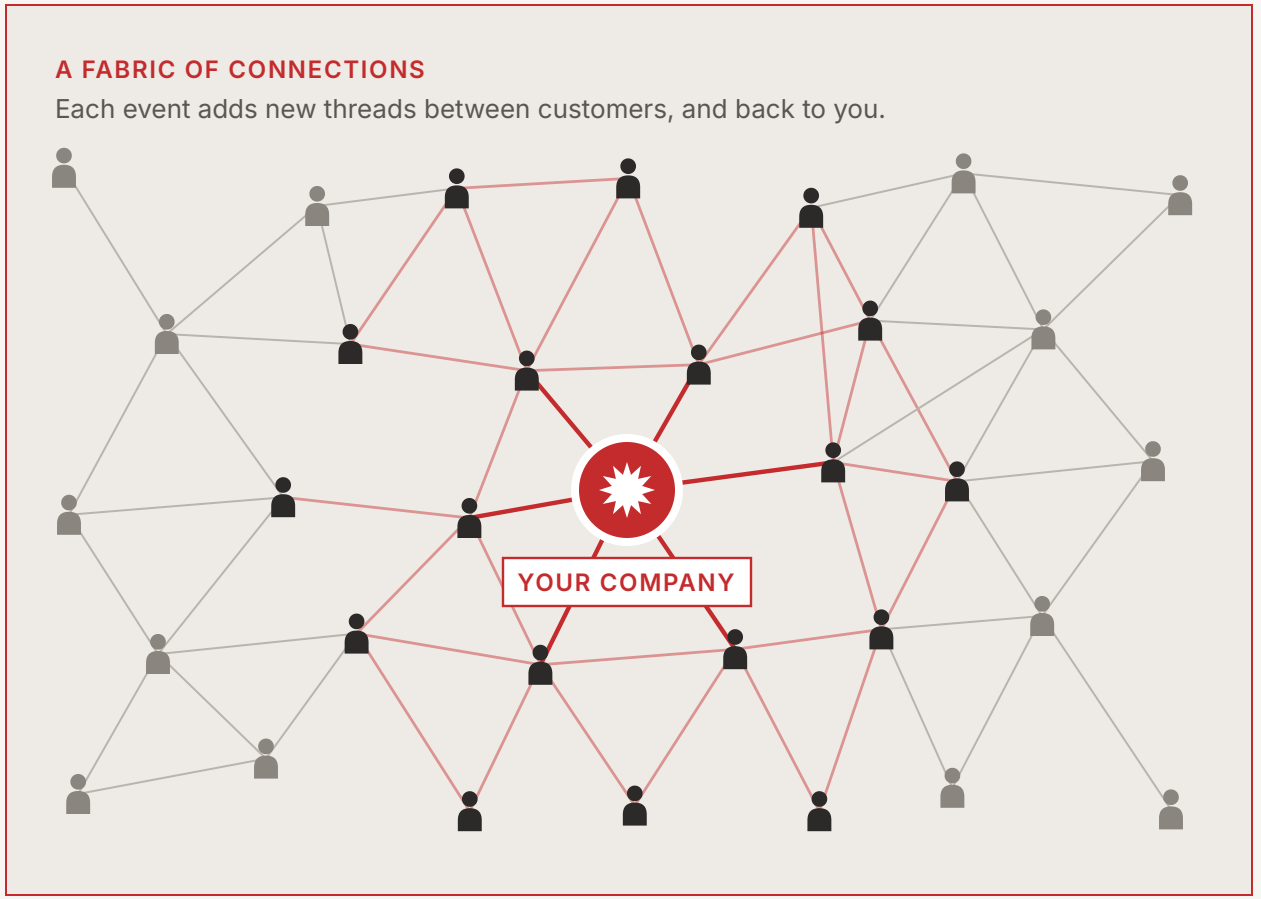
THE RESULT

Social *capital*

THE GOODWILL OF POTENTIAL CUSTOMERS.

Hosting experiential marketing increases a company's social capital. It creates a fabric of connections, reciprocity and trustworthiness, leading to growth in agentic, digitally saturated economies.

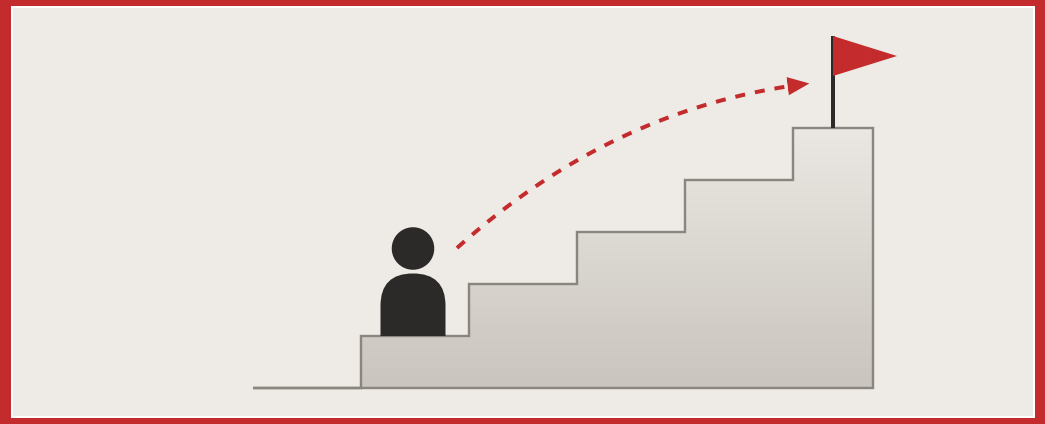




QUESTION 02 · MOTIVATION

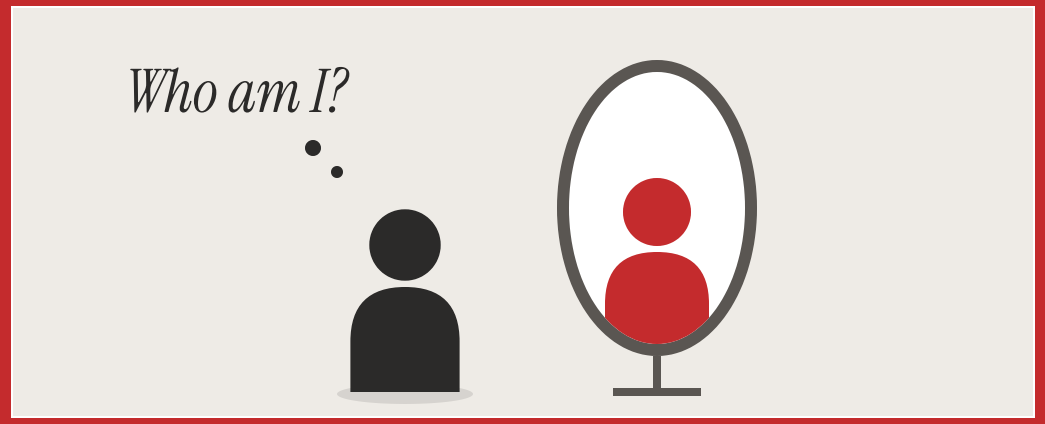
Why people *show up*

WHAT MOTIVATES PARTICIPANTS TO JOIN IN-PERSON EVENTS?



01 *Basic human needs*

The pursuit of happiness.

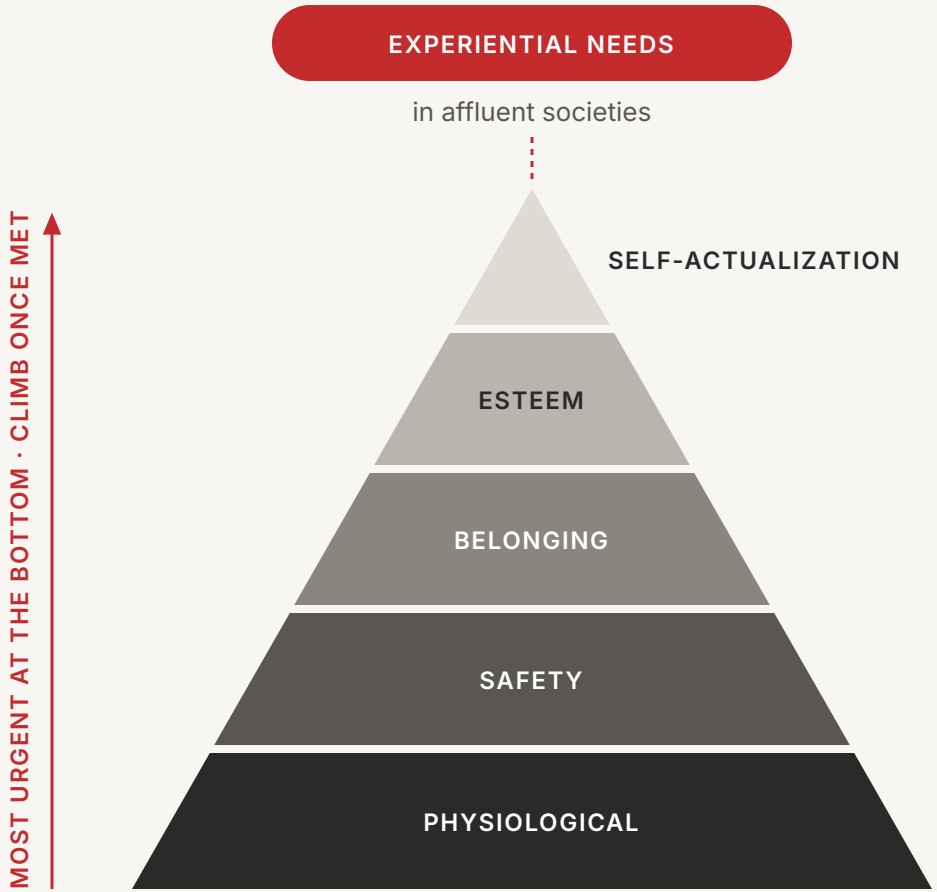


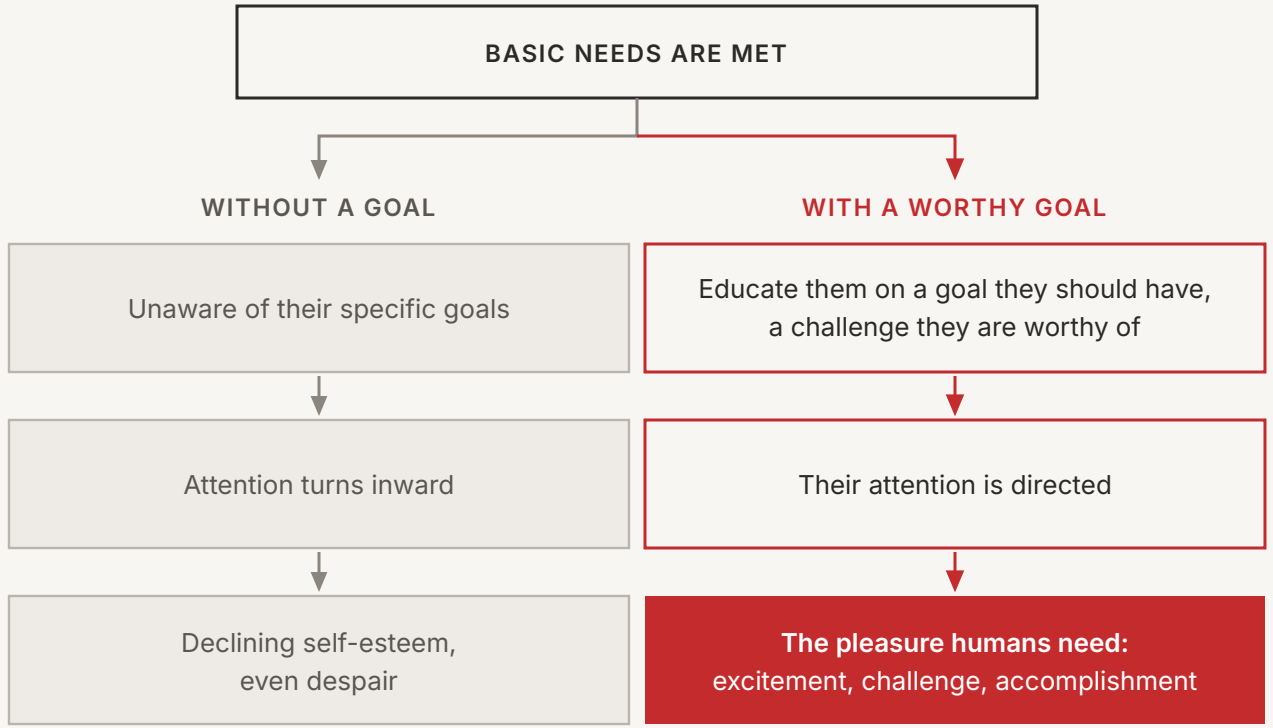
02 *Identification with self*

Who am I? And reinforcing that to others.

Beyond *Maslow*

WHERE BASIC NEEDS ARE MET, PEOPLE ALSO HAVE EXPERIENTIAL NEEDS.





Experiential needs are the desire for a goal and the continuous pursuit of excitement, challenges and personal accomplishment.

AN EVERYDAY EXAMPLE

Shopping as a *goal*

SHOPPING OFFERS A GOAL: IMPROVING ONE'S QUALITY OF LIFE.

That is what makes it enjoyable: it gives the buyer a goal worth pursuing. The higher the risk of a bad purchase, the more emotional, involved and potentially enjoyable shopping becomes, and the more motivated the customer is to participate voluntarily in experiential marketing.



Who am *I*?

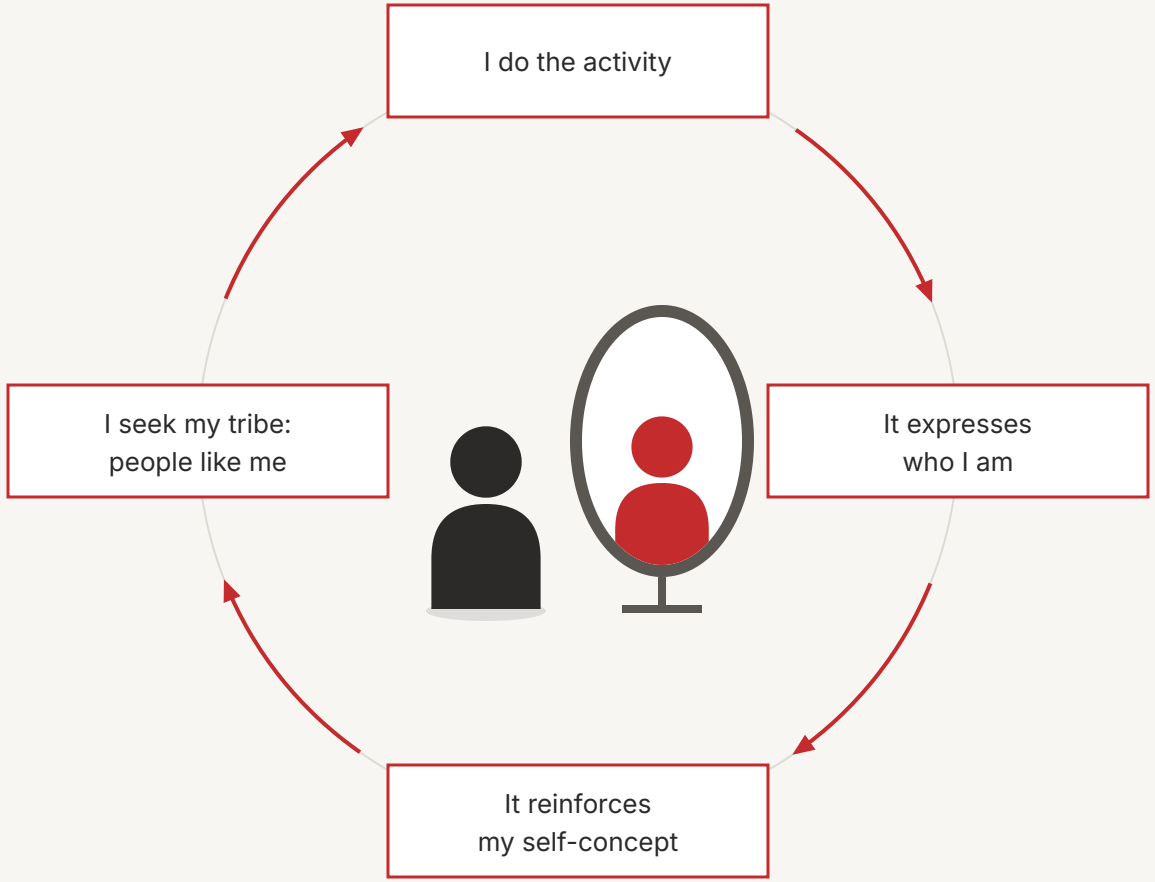
IDENTITY-BASED MOTIVATION: DOING THE ACTIVITY IS AN EXPRESSION OF WHO I AM.

Engaging in it reinforces a person's self-concept. Sociologists have long studied our desire to belong to tribes: groups of people who identify like “I do”.

People rarely feel comfortable networking, or natural and true to themselves in a networking environment.

YET

Identity motivation is stronger than material gain or self-interest.



WHO TO INVITE, AND HOW

Two *tribes*

IN B2B, IDENTITY MOTIVATION LOOKS DIFFERENT FOR EXTROVERTS AND INTROVERTS.



Networkers

EASIEST TO ENGAGE

Ambitious extroverts who see growing their network as instrumental to professional success. They want visibility, take part in professional communities, maintain their social contacts and want to be known as industry leaders.

FORMATS THAT WORK

- ROUND-TABLES
- BREAKFAST DISCUSSIONS
- AFTER-WORKS



CTOs & engineers

GIVE THEM A CHALLENGE

An introverted group, and often the target customer. Motivate them with a worthy goal: a challenge related to their leisure activity of building new ideas. It opens an interactive dialogue between the customer and the company.

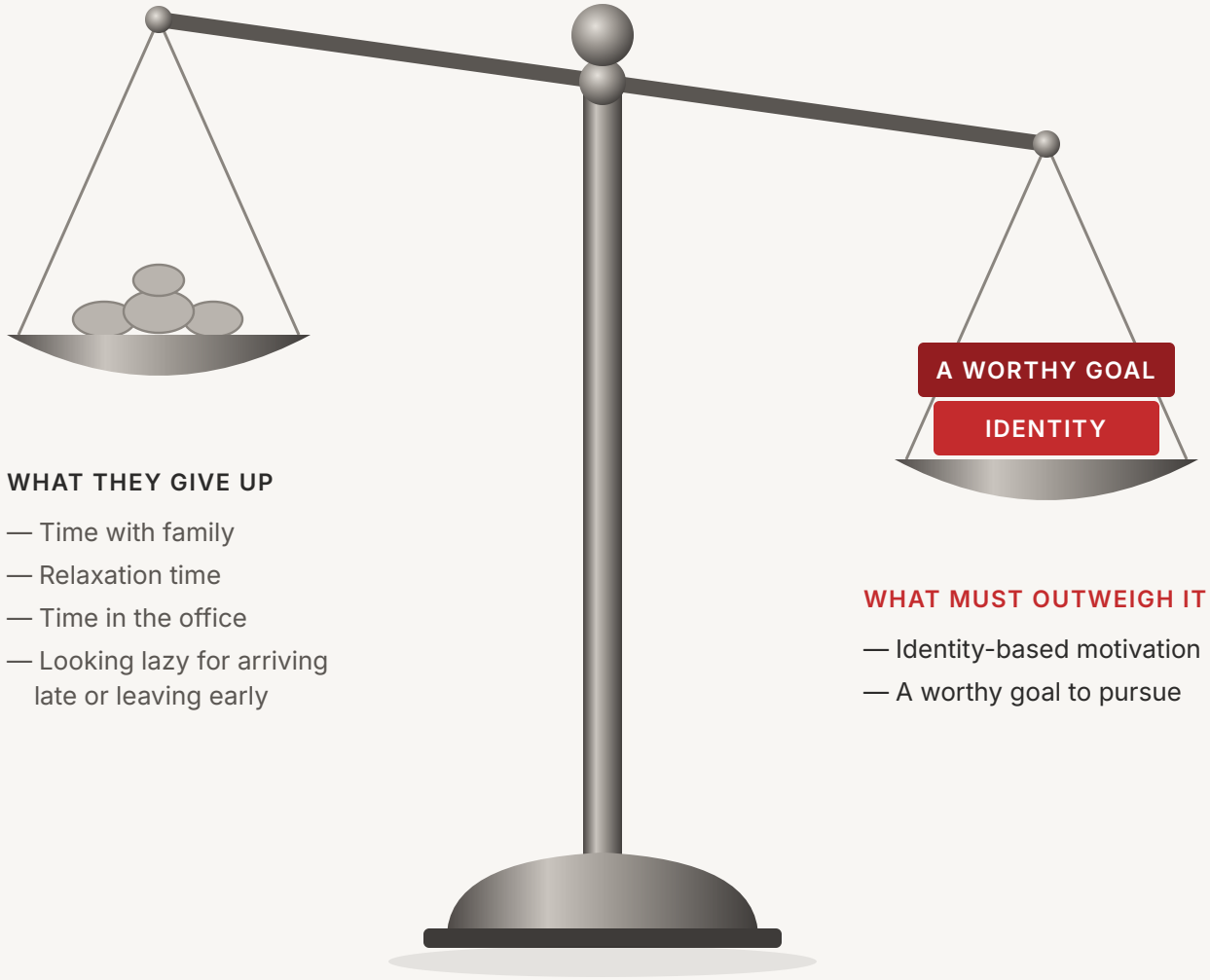
FORMATS THAT WORK

- HACKATHONS

The price of *showing up*

Attending an event means sacrificing time with family, relaxation time or time in the office, where, in extreme cases, arriving late or leaving early can make someone look lazy.

To make the investment feel worth it, the activity must engage identity-based motivation and the human need to pursue a worthy goal.



WHAT THEY GIVE UP

— Time with family
— Relaxation time
— Time in the office
— Looking lazy for arriving late or leaving early

WHAT MUST OUTWEIGH IT

— Identity-based motivation
— A worthy goal to pursue

The *flywheel*

EXPERIENTIAL MARKETING DEPENDS ON VOLUNTARY PARTICIPATION.

To engage customers, relate to their leisure activities and their sense of self, then reinforce that sense of self by creating goals for that audience. This satisfies their experiential needs, grows your social capital and gives customers a tribe they relate to.



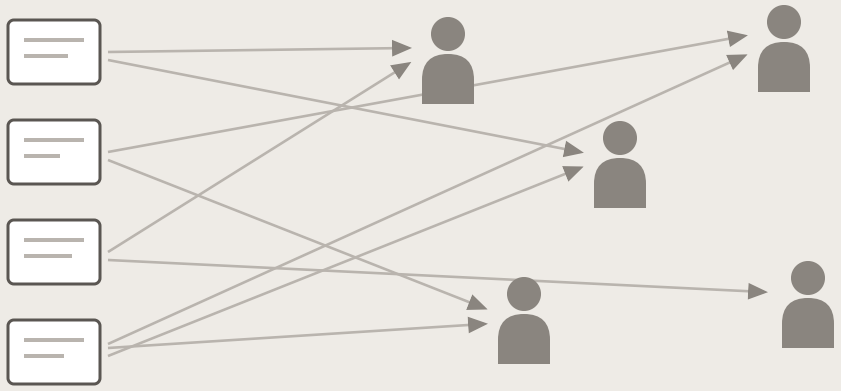
IN CLOSING

From monologue to *tribe*

THE PURPOSE OF ALL MARKETING: LONG-TERM, TRUST-BASED RELATIONSHIPS WITH CUSTOMERS.

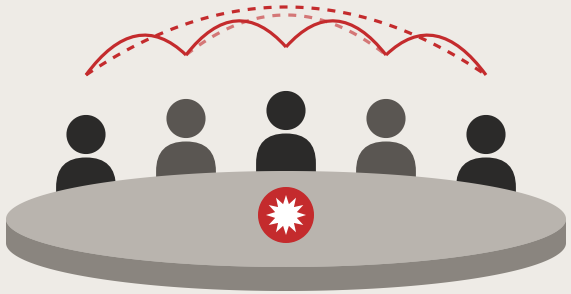
BEFORE · PUSHED MESSAGES

A monologue on digitally saturated channels



AFTER · CO-CREATED IDENTITY

Customers connected to one another, and to you



Experiential marketing co-creates identity-based motivation, connecting customers to one another.

AWARENESS | **TRUST** | **CREDIBILITY** | **DEMAND FOR FUTURE EXPERIENCES**

ALEXANDRA STUDIO · THE OPERATOR NETWORK

In real *life*



WE BRING BUYERS AND COMPANIES TOGETHER IN REAL LIFE.

I'm Alexandra, founder of Alexandra Studio and the Operator Network. We believe this is the future of sales in our new world of AI: real people, real conversations, and the customer's choice to self-identify with our clients' brands, leading to better customer relationships, trust and purchasing.

GET IN TOUCH!

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